

SYRIA HIGHER EDUCATION BRIEF

How the War Changed Universities in Syria

The war did not just damage campuses. It changed university safety, governance, staffing, student access, study patterns, and the practical value of degrees.

Main takeaway

Syrian universities still exist, but the war reshaped them from relatively stable public institutions into a system marked by insecurity, politicization, faculty loss, unequal access, and weaker career portability.

2011–

long conflict period that transformed higher education conditions

2016

latest non-null World Bank/UIS-linked tertiary enrollment data I retrieved

43.8%

gross tertiary enrollment ratio in Syria in 2016

697k

total tertiary enrollment in Syria in 2016

01 Campuses became unsafe

Universities, dormitories, and teaching spaces were damaged, militarized, or exposed to shelling and raids. A 2024 Aleppo University dormitory strike shows universities remained vulnerable long after the war began.

02 Security control deepened

Evidence points to stronger surveillance, intimidation, and political-security influence over campus life and management. This narrowed academic freedom and changed the everyday experience of studying.

03 Faculty losses weakened quality

Displacement, exile, deaths, disappearances, and conscription reduced the stock of experienced professors. Some institutions relied more heavily on junior or less specialized staff, weakening teaching and research.

04 Access changed in two opposite ways

Admission thresholds often fell as demand collapsed, but real participation became harder because of poverty, insecurity, transport barriers, document problems, and fear of arrest or military service.

05 The student body shifted

Reports suggest women became a larger share of students after 2011, partly because men were more affected by migration and militarization. Online and flexible learning became more important.

06 Degrees became less portable

Recognition and labor-market value became less reliable in some areas, especially across conflict lines and outside Syria. University became a less predictable route into employment and mobility.

What stayed true

- Syria still has a centralized higher-education system on paper.
- Public universities, private universities, open education, and Syrian Virtual University continue to exist.
- The sector survived, but under severe long-term damage.

Important caution

- Recent national higher-education data are sparse.
- Best system-wide analytical evidence is strongest for 2017–2019, with some newer incident reporting.
- Conditions vary sharply across institutions and regions.

Sources:

Cambridge/CARA report (2019): educ.cam.ac.uk/.../190606-REPORT-2-POST-2011-FINAL-ENGLISH.pdf
Scholars at Risk (2013; 2024): scholarsatrisk.org/.../syrian-universities-in-the-uprising/ · scholarsatrisk.org/.../2024-11-29-university-of-aleppo/
Official system overview: studyinsyria.sy/en/syrian-higher-education-system
World Bank API: SE.TER.ENRR · SE.TER.ENRR

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